



THE EVEREST restaurant in Altadena, foreground, was destroyed, as was a Montessori school, right, and Bryan's Cleaners & Laundry, left. The fire destroyed more than 9,400 residential and commercial structures.

After fire, small businesses in Altadena face a crisis

Some burned down. Others are ‘silent casualties’ as clients are displaced.

By Andrea Chang and Marisa Gerber

The blackened remains of the neighborhood pet store next to a bank untouched by the fires.

A burned-down museum of bunny memorabilia separated by red caution tape from a strip mall, all of its businesses still standing.

A longtime bike shop, reduced

to a heap of twisted metal, steps away from a pristine Thai restaurant with a handwritten note taped to the door: “Sorry, we are closed due to power outage and extreme winds. Come back soon!”

Up and down Lake Avenue, the main commercial thoroughfare in Altadena, are stark signs of the Eaton fire’s aftermath: the businesses it subsumed and the ones it spared. More than 9,400 residential

and commercial structures were destroyed by the blaze, a catastrophic loss for the tight-knit community nestled in the foothills of the San Gabriel Mountains.

All told, estimates of the total economic loss from last month’s wildfires in and around Los Angeles have swelled to more than \$250 billion, making it one of the costliest natural disasters in U.S.

Musk takes showdown to new levels

Billionaire tears at traditional democracy to make way for Trump’s new order.

By Kevin Rector

The world’s richest man, acting as an unelected “efficiency” consultant to President Trump, has in recent days managed the rare feat of overshadowing his boss — presuming to storm into and begin closing out government agencies at will.

After two weeks of chaos caused by Trump’s own unilateral executive orders to radically alter the federal government, it was suddenly Elon Musk whose name was everywhere in Washington this week, as he and his deputies in the new, so-called Department of Government Efficiency, or DOGE, slashed at the federal bureaucracy in a purported effort to cut costs.

Disregarding established security protocols while

downplaying the budgetary authority of Congress, they accessed sensitive Treasury Department systems full of Americans’ most personal data and declared that the U.S. Agency for International Development — the agency long in charge of distributing American foreign aid to places such as Gaza, Ukraine and sub-Saharan Africa — was corrupt and being closed.

They suggested anyone who stood in their way, including career civil servants with actual authority to safeguard Treasury and USAID data, were the real rogue agents. And they and their allies dismissed rising outrage among Democrats as the whining resistance of po-

Trump wants U.S. to take over Gaza

He doesn’t rule out deploying troops and wants to move Palestinians for good. **PERSPECTIVES, A2**

Federal job cuts hit national parks

Trump administration axes seasonal workers. Insiders warn of chaos at much-prized sites.

By Jack Dolan

As the Trump administration rushes to cut spending and eliminate federal jobs, even the people who work at the national parks — among the country’s most beloved and least politicized institutions — find themselves directly in the crosshairs.

Last month, the seasonal workers who staff 433 national parks and historical sites, including Yosemite, Death Valley and Joshua Tree, began receiving emails

saying their job offers for the 2025 season had been “rescinded,” with little further explanation.

The move set off panic in the ranks of park employees and threw into limbo the vacation plans of hundreds of millions of people who visit the parks each year. On the chopping block are hundreds — and potentially thousands — of park rangers who respond to medical emergencies, as well as visitor center employees and the crews that clean bathrooms and empty garbage cans.

In many of the larger and most popular parks, seasonal workers outnumber year-round permanent employees, making it hard to imagine how the parks will

THE WIDE SHOT

Hollywood headed toward ghost town

Film and TV shoots are leaving Los Angeles in the rearview mirror.

By Ryan Faughnder

Among the pleasures of seeing the hit buddy comedy “One of Them Days” over the weekend was that jolt of recognition at the sight of a genuine Los Angeles landmark on the big screen: the Norms restaurant on La Cienega Boulevard, where Keke Palmer’s striving character works, one of the country’s best remaining examples of Google-style architecture.

The film from first-time feature director Lawrence Lamont, starring Palmer and Grammy-winning musician SZA, is an unusual creation from Hollywood, and not just because it’s the kind of light, original comedy that studios supposedly don’t

make anymore. (So far, it has grossed a winning \$34.5 million on a reported \$14-million budget.)

It’s also a reminder of how few successful movies are actually filmed in Los Angeles these days, despite the fact that the studios and production firms are mostly still headquartered here, including Sony Pictures, its TriStar unit and Charles D. King’s Macro, the companies responsible for “One of Them Days.”

Southern California’s entertainment economy has taken a beating over the last few years. The COVID-19 pandemic, two overlapping labor strikes and the pull-back of overspending during the streaming wars compounded a structural problem for the movie business’ hometown: It costs too much to film here.

Film and TV shoots have fled for cheaper locales, enticed by generous tax incentives [See **Hollywood, A7**]

COLUMN ONE

In Malibu, she was the star of the show



Betty O'Meara owned and operated the 200-plus-seat Malibu Cinema with her husband, David, for nearly 20 years.

By James Rainey

Betty O'Meara's signature was a resolute brand of hospitality. It blossomed with her friends and umpteen pen pals and reached full flower at the Malibu Cinema, the movie theater that she and her husband operated for two decades in the heart of Malibu.

At the cozy cinema on Cross Creek Road, you could take in a double feature for less than \$5, sit in an audience that might include Bob Dylan, Dyan Cannon or Burt Lancaster and be tickled by the squawking of the cockatoo that made its home atop the snack counter.

The theater was a cherished gathering place for a town filled with people who often had moved to Malibu from somewhere else.

China retaliates over U.S. tariffs

Beijing targets fuel and other imports and hits Google with antitrust inquiry. **WORLD, A3**

Malibu protests plan for debris

Residents and city say hazardous waste should not be stored close to schools. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

A little morning rain. L.A. Basin: 63/55. **B6**

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